

Exclusivity breeds piracy

NETFLIX AND SIMILAR STREAMING SERVICES

not only helped make things convenient for folks to consume content but it also helped break the strangulating hold that major studios had over the entertainment industry. However, there's no way that the studios were going to take this lying down. Almost every major group has started coming out with their own streaming service. Until then, most folks would need to subscribe to 1-2 services to get the entire gamut of shows and movies. Throw in regional pack to appease the folks back home and you've now realised that you're paying more these 2-3 services than what you used to pay your local cable guy. The DTH operators killed the local cable monopoly and the online streaming services are in the process of killing off DTH service providers. Since the online streaming segment didn't have a lot of players, we started seeing conglomerates such as Amazon step in with their Prime Video service. Then we had regional players such as Hotstar and the likes come into the picture.

Now, if all the major service providers were to have the same set of content, then folks will simply subscribe to the cheapest option available. To prevent this, streaming services starting aligning themselves with certain studios and also started shooting original programming. The former is obviously, not for the good of the consumer, the latter on the other hand, is great! With hollywood studios signing exclusive agreements with certain providers, the consumer is forced to obtain more than one subscription and that's where it stops being convenient. Switching between services is still tolerable but having to get a subscription just to watch one or two shows is ridiculous. Moreover, it's not financially viable for the average consumer to have multiple subscriptions. So people start looking for loopholes to gain access to the content. Do note, that they're still going at it the legal way. For example, with Netflix you can share your 4K account with four individuals and each person only has to pony up 200 for access to 4K content. It's not as easy with Prime Video.

It's not as if folks can't afford the 4K subscription, just that it's a simple solution to the content fragmentation issue. Last we heard, Disney is coming out with their own streaming service and is cutting ties with existing stream-

ing services so that Disney content remains exclusive to the Disney platform. While Disney has a lot of good content, the folks who'd subscribed to existing platforms aren't happy about this new development. Sandvine, a research company found out that the rise of competing services is leading more people to pirate content off the internet. BitTorrent traffic, which once dominated the Internet pipelines, saw a massive decline from 2011 to 2015, and has now started to see a rise. A glance at the most popular torrents or the most seeded torrents on these BitTorrent search engines shows that folks are pirating these exclusive TV shows and movies the most. Simply put, studio executives think that exclusives help retain consumers and while that is true, data shows that exclusivity fosters the illegal market.

If you check TorrentFreak's weekly traffic tracker post, then you will find exclusives dominating the list every week. New episode of Game of Thrones came out on Sunday night? Guess what starts trending within one hour on all BitTorrent search engines? The exact same episode.

Exclusivity, no matter what kind of content has always been perceived in a negative manner. Even with console architectures being the same (Xbox and PS both use AMD x86 CPUs and GPUs) we still see platform exclusive video games, only that Xbox seems to be on the losing front while Sony continues to rake in all the moolah. Exclusives are the only reason Xbox even sells. They've made quite a few announcements that didn't go down well with the gamers and for that they lost fans. In the streaming segment, everyone except Netflix seems to be losing the original content war. All we can do now is wait for these folk to fight it out down to the last penny as revenues keep dropping and consumers keep pirating content. If only, things were simpler. 



"The DTH operators killed the local cable monopoly and the online streaming services are in the process of killing off DTH service providers."



Let me know your thoughts on this column at:

@mithun_mohandas |
mithun@digit.in